

CLEARQUOTE TECHNOLOGIES INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED

Human Resources Policy Division

EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

Policies, Conduct & Workplace Guidelines

Version 3.2 | Effective 01 January 2026

Document Classification: Internal — All Employees

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Table of Contents

(Updates to field codes may be required if opened in some viewers — right-click and 'Update Field' in Word.)

1. Welcome & Purpose of This Handbook

Welcome to ClearQuote Technologies India Private Limited ("the Company", "ClearQuote"). This handbook has been prepared to give every employee a clear, consistent reference for the policies, expectations, and benefits that govern our workplace. It applies to all full-time, part-time, fixed-term, and contract staff across every office and remote location unless a specific policy states otherwise.

This handbook does not constitute an employment contract, nor does it guarantee employment for any specific duration. The Company reserves the right to amend, suspend, or replace any policy in this document at its discretion, with reasonable notice communicated through official Company channels, including the HR portal, email circulars, and town halls.

1.1 How to Use This Handbook

Employees are expected to read this handbook in full within the first two weeks of joining and to sign the acknowledgement form in Section 31. Managers should treat this document as the baseline reference when advising their teams; where a team or project has more specific guidance (for example, an engineering runbook or a client-specific security addendum), the stricter of the two policies applies.

1.2 Scope & Applicability

Unless a clause states a narrower scope, every policy in this handbook applies uniformly across all functions — engineering, data science, product, sales, operations, and support — and across all Company locations, including Chennai, Bengaluru, and any registered branch office, as well as employees working from approved remote locations within India.

1.3 Precedence of Documents

In the event of a conflict between this handbook and an individual's signed offer letter or employment agreement, the employment agreement prevails. In the event of a conflict between this handbook and statutory law, the applicable law prevails. Any ambiguity should be raised with People & Culture (P&C) for clarification rather than assumed.

2. Company Overview

ClearQuote Technologies designs and delivers applied machine learning and data platforms for enterprise clients, with active practice areas in natural language processing, computer vision, forecasting, and retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) systems for knowledge-intensive workflows. Our engineering culture values rigorous experimentation, reproducibility, and the responsible deployment of AI systems into production.

2.1 Mission & Values

- Build systems that are reliable, explainable, and safe by default.
- Treat data — customer data and each other's personal data — with the same care we would want for our own.
- Ship iteratively, measure honestly, and document decisions so the next engineer doesn't start from zero.
- Grow technical depth through mentorship, code review, and shared post-mortems, not blame.
- Prefer boring, well-understood technology over novelty for its own sake, unless the novelty earns its complexity.

2.2 Locations & Structure

The Company's registered office is located at Unit C, Mezzanine Floor, East Coast Chambers, Old No. 92, G.N. Chetty Road, T. Nagar, Chennai 600017. Additional delivery centres and client-facing teams may operate from other approved locations as communicated by Facilities and updated in the HR portal's office directory.

2.3 Organisational Functions

Function	Primary Responsibility
Engineering	Design, build, and operate ML/AI systems and supporting infrastructure
Data Science & Research	Model research, experimentation, evaluation, and applied research
Product	Roadmap definition, requirements, and client success alignment
Client Delivery	Implementation, deployment, and post-launch support for client engagements
People & Culture	Recruitment, onboarding, policy, employee relations, and benefits
Finance & Legal	Payroll, compliance, contracts, and statutory filings
Information Security	Security architecture, incident response, and compliance audits

3. Employment Classification & Probation

Category	Description	Benefits Eligibility
Full-Time (Regular)	Minimum 40 hrs/week, ongoing engagement	Full benefits per Section 13
Part-Time	Fewer than 30 hrs/week, ongoing engagement	Pro-rated benefits
Fixed-Term Contract	Engagement for a defined project or period	As specified in offer letter
Intern / Trainee	Structured learning engagement, typically 3–6 months	Stipend; limited benefits
Consultant / Contractor	Engaged via statement of work, not payroll	Per contractual terms

3.1 Probationary Period

New full-time employees serve a probationary period of six months from the date of joining, extendable by up to three months at the Company's discretion where further evaluation is needed. During probation, either party may terminate the engagement with 30 days' written notice or payment in lieu.

3.2 Confirmation

Confirmation of employment following probation is based on a formal review conducted jointly by the reporting manager and People & Culture, covering role competency, collaboration, and adherence to Company policy. Confirmation letters are issued through the HR portal and should be retained by the employee for personal records.

4. Recruitment & Onboarding

4.1 Fair Hiring Practices

All recruitment decisions are based on merit, skills, and role fit. Hiring managers must use structured interview scorecards for technical and behavioural rounds, and at least one interviewer independent of the hiring manager's direct chain must participate in the final loop for roles at Senior Engineer level and above.

4.2 Employee Referral Programme

Employees may refer candidates through the HR portal's referral module. Referral bonuses are paid in two tranches — 50% on the referred candidate's confirmation of employment, and 50% on completion of six months of continuous service — and are subject to the referral policy's eligibility rules, including a cooling-off period for candidates who applied independently within the prior 90 days.

4.3 Background Verification

All offers of employment are contingent on satisfactory completion of background verification, covering identity, education, prior employment, and where applicable, criminal record checks, conducted through an authorised third-party verification partner in accordance with data protection requirements.

4.4 Onboarding Journey

1. Pre-boarding: offer acceptance, document collection, and IT asset provisioning request raised at least 5 working days before the joining date.
2. Day 1: HR orientation, policy briefing, workstation and account setup, and introduction to the reporting manager and immediate team.
3. Week 1: role-specific technical onboarding, access provisioning to required repositories and systems, and assignment of an onboarding buddy.
4. 30/60/90-day check-ins: structured conversations with the manager and People & Culture to track ramp-up, address blockers, and set early goals.

5. Code of Conduct

5.1 Professional Behaviour

Every employee is expected to act with honesty, respect, and professionalism in all interactions with colleagues, clients, vendors, and the public — in person, in writing, and on internal communication platforms. Disagreement on technical or business decisions is welcomed when expressed constructively; personal attacks, sarcasm intended to belittle, and public shaming of colleagues are not acceptable regardless of seniority.

5.2 Anti-Harassment & Non-Discrimination

The Company maintains zero tolerance for harassment, discrimination, or retaliation based on race, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, religion, caste, age, disability, marital status, or any other characteristic protected by applicable law. Complaints may be raised confidentially with People & Culture or through the anonymous ethics line described in Section 24. Full procedural detail on sexual harassment complaints is set out in Section 8 (POSH Policy).

5.3 Conflicts of Interest

Employees must disclose any outside engagement, financial interest, or relationship that could reasonably be seen to conflict with the Company's interests, including consulting work, board positions, side projects that compete with Company offerings, or close personal relationships with vendors or direct reports. Disclosures are made via the annual Conflict of Interest declaration and updated promptly whenever circumstances change.

5.4 Anti-Bribery & Gifts

Employees may not offer, solicit, or accept bribes, kickbacks, or gifts of material value in connection with Company business. Customary business courtesies below the threshold defined in the Finance Policy (currently ₹2,500 per instance, ₹10,000 aggregate per year from a single source) may be accepted with manager awareness and must be logged in the gifts register maintained by Finance.

5.5 Dress Code

The Company follows a smart-casual dress code for regular working days, with business-formal attire expected for client-facing meetings, external events, and days when senior client stakeholders visit the office. Individual teams may adopt reasonable variations for practical reasons (for example, lab or hardware work).

5.6 Use of Company Property

Company equipment, software licences, and facilities are provided for business use. Limited incidental personal use is permitted provided it does not interfere with work, violate security policy, or incur material

cost to the Company. Employees are personally accountable for equipment issued to them and must report loss or damage to IT within 24 hours.

5.7 Political & Religious Activity

Employees may hold personal political or religious views, but Company premises, email systems, and branding may not be used to campaign, solicit, or proselytise. Employees speaking publicly on political or religious topics must make clear they speak in a personal capacity and not on behalf of the Company.

6. Diversity, Equity & Inclusion

ClearQuote is committed to building a workforce that reflects a wide range of backgrounds, perspectives, and lived experience, in the belief that diverse teams build better, less biased technology — a principle we hold especially important for teams building machine learning systems that make or influence decisions about people.

6.1 Inclusive Hiring

Job descriptions are reviewed for inclusive language before posting, and interview panels are encouraged to include a diverse mix of interviewers wherever feasible. The Company partners with organisations supporting under-represented groups in technology to widen the talent pipeline.

6.2 Accessibility & Accommodation

Employees with disabilities, temporary or permanent, may request reasonable workplace accommodations — including equipment, flexible scheduling, or remote-work arrangements — by contacting People & Culture. Requests are reviewed promptly and confidentially, in consultation with the employee's manager only where necessary to implement the accommodation.

6.3 Employee Resource Groups

Employees may form or join voluntary Employee Resource Groups (ERGs) focused on shared identity or interest, such as Women in Tech or Early-Career Engineers. ERGs may request modest budget support for events through People & Culture.

7. Attendance & Leave Policy

7.1 Working Days & Attendance Codes

Attendance is recorded daily through the Company's HR system. The standard status codes used across attendance reports are:

Code	Meaning
P	Present — full working day recorded
A	Absent — no leave applied or approved
H	Holiday — declared Company or public holiday
COF	Compensatory Off — earned day off in lieu of extra working day
LOP	Loss of Pay — unpaid day, typically after leave balance is exhausted
WFH	Approved Work From Home day
OD	On Duty — working off-site on official Company business, e.g. client site or conference

7.2 Leave Entitlement

Leave Type	Annual Entitlement	Carry-Forward
Earned / Privilege Leave	18 days	Up to 10 days into next year
Sick Leave	10 days	Not carried forward
Casual Leave	6 days	Not carried forward
Maternity Leave	26 weeks (as per statute)	N/A
Paternity Leave	10 working days	N/A
Adoption Leave	12 weeks (primary caregiver)	N/A
Bereavement Leave	5 working days	N/A
Marriage Leave	3 working days (once per employment)	N/A
Sabbatical (post 3 years' service)	Up to 90 days, unpaid, subject to approval	N/A
Jury / Civic Duty Leave	As required by summons, with proof	N/A

7.3 Applying for Leave

5. Submit a leave request through the HR portal at least 3 working days in advance for planned leave.
6. For unplanned or sick leave, notify your manager before the start of the working day, and file the request in the portal within 48 hours.
7. Leave exceeding 5 consecutive working days requires an additional sign-off from the department head.
8. Unapproved absence beyond the entitled balance will be recorded as Loss of Pay (LOP) and deducted pro-rata from the monthly salary, as illustrated in the attendance and payslip examples referenced by Finance.

7.4 Public Holidays

The Company observes a minimum of 10 declared public and festival holidays each calendar year, published by People & Culture in December for the following year and listed in Appendix A. Employees required to work on a declared holiday for business continuity reasons are entitled to a Compensatory Off (COF), to be availed within 60 days.

8. Prevention of Sexual Harassment (POSH) Policy

In compliance with the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013, and as a matter of principle applied to all employees regardless of gender, the Company maintains an Internal Committee (IC) to receive, investigate, and resolve complaints of sexual harassment.

8.1 What Constitutes Sexual Harassment

Sexual harassment includes unwelcome physical contact, demands or requests for sexual favours, sexually coloured remarks, showing pornography, and any other unwelcome physical, verbal, or non-verbal conduct of a sexual nature, whether occurring on Company premises, at client sites, during official travel, or on digital platforms used for work.

8.2 Internal Committee Composition

The Internal Committee comprises a Presiding Officer (a senior woman employee), at least two employee members with a demonstrated commitment to the cause, and one external member from a non-governmental organisation familiar with issues of sexual harassment. Contact details for current IC members are published on the HR portal and refreshed whenever membership changes.

8.3 Complaint Procedure

9. A complaint may be filed in writing (including email) within 3 months of the incident, extendable by the IC in appropriate circumstances.
10. The IC will provide the respondent a copy of the complaint within 7 days and complete the inquiry within 90 days.
11. During the inquiry, the IC may recommend interim measures, such as transfer of either party or leave for the complainant.
12. Findings and recommendations are submitted to management within 10 days of completing the inquiry, and action is implemented within 60 days thereafter.
13. Both parties have the right to appeal the IC's findings through the process prescribed under the Act.

8.4 Confidentiality & Protection Against Retaliation

The identity of the complainant, respondent, and witnesses is kept strictly confidential throughout the process. Retaliation against a complainant or witness is treated as an independent, serious disciplinary offence.

9. Working Hours & Flexible Work

Standard working hours are 9:30 AM to 6:30 PM, Monday through Friday, with a one-hour lunch break. Engineering teams operating in a hybrid model may adopt flexible start times between 8:00 AM and 10:30 AM, provided a minimum of 4 overlapping "core hours" with the immediate team is maintained.

9.1 Time Tracking

Employees log attendance via the HR system's biometric terminal (in-office) or the mobile check-in feature (remote), consistent with the attendance report format used for monthly payroll reconciliation. Managers review team attendance summaries monthly and flag discrepancies to People & Culture before the payroll cut-off.

9.2 Overtime

Overtime for eligible non-exempt roles must be pre-approved by a manager and is compensated at 1.5× the standard hourly rate, or compensated with time off in lieu (COF) at management's discretion, in line with local labour law. Salaried engineering roles above the designated grade threshold are exempt from overtime pay but are expected to manage workload sustainably in partnership with their manager.

9.3 On-Call & Production Support

Engineers on production on-call rotations receive an on-call allowance as defined in the Compensation Policy, and any active incident response outside standard hours is compensated as overtime or COF regardless of exempt status. On-call schedules must guarantee a minimum 11-hour rest period between rotations.

10. Remote & Hybrid Work Policy

The Company supports hybrid work as the default model for most roles, balancing focused remote work with in-person collaboration. Fully remote arrangements may be approved for specific roles or circumstances at management's discretion.

10.1 In-Office Collaboration Days

Each team designates at least two collaboration days per week, published on the team calendar, during which co-located members are expected in the office for planning, pairing, and design reviews.

10.2 Home Office Standards

Employees working remotely must maintain a dedicated, reasonably quiet workspace with a stable internet connection of at least 20 Mbps, and must join video calls from a private setting when discussing client or confidential information.

10.3 Equipment for Remote Work

The Company provides a laptop, and eligible employees may claim a one-time home-office setup allowance (see Section 13.4) for a monitor, chair, or desk. All equipment remains Company property and must be returned on separation.

10.4 Security Expectations While Remote

Remote employees must connect to Company systems only via the approved VPN, must not use public, unsecured Wi-Fi for work involving client or model training data, and must lock or log off devices when unattended. Full detail is in Section 16 (Information Security Policy).

11. Performance Management

11.1 Review Cycle

Performance is reviewed twice yearly: a mid-year check-in in June and an annual review in December.

Reviews combine self-assessment, manager assessment, and — for senior technical roles — peer and cross-functional feedback gathered through a structured 360-degree process.

11.2 Goal Setting

Employees set quarterly OKRs (Objectives and Key Results) in collaboration with their manager. For engineering roles, at least one objective per quarter should map to a measurable technical or delivery outcome — for example, inference latency, retrieval precision/recall for a RAG pipeline, model accuracy, system reliability, or shipped features.

11.3 Rating Scale

Rating	Description
Exceptional	Consistently exceeds expectations; significant, visible impact beyond role scope
Exceeds Expectations	Regularly delivers beyond agreed goals with high quality
Meets Expectations	Reliably delivers agreed goals to a good standard
Partially Meets Expectations	Delivers some goals; specific, addressable gaps identified
Below Expectations	Consistent shortfall against role expectations; formal improvement plan required

11.4 Performance Improvement Plans (PIP)

Where performance is rated Below Expectations, or where specific serious concerns arise outside the standard cycle, the manager and People & Culture will place the employee on a Performance Improvement Plan (PIP) with clear, time-bound, measurable goals — typically over 30 to 60 days — with structured check-ins. Failure to meet PIP goals may lead to further action up to and including termination, per Section 25 (Disciplinary Policy).

11.5 Promotion & Career Ladders

Technical career progression follows a dual-track ladder (Individual Contributor and Management) so engineers can advance in scope and compensation without moving into people management. Promotion decisions are calibrated in cross-team panels to ensure consistency, with published competency matrices available on the HR portal for each level from Associate Engineer through Principal Engineer / Engineering Director.

12. Compensation Structure

12.1 Salary Components

Compensation is structured into fixed and variable components. Fixed pay typically includes a base component along with allowances such as Shift Allowance and Sunday Working pay where applicable, consistent with the earnings breakdown shown on the monthly payslip (for example, Contractor Fees, Holiday Pay, Sunday Working, and Shift Allowance line items).

Component	Description
Base / Contractor Fees	Core monthly compensation tied to role and grade
Performance Bonus	Discretionary, linked to individual and Company performance
Holiday Pay	Compensation for approved work on declared holidays
Sunday / Weekend Working	Additional pay for approved weekend work
Shift Allowance	Applicable to roles working outside standard day shift
Statutory Deductions	Income Tax (TDS), Provident Fund, and Professional Tax as applicable

12.2 Pay Cycle & Payslips

Salaries are computed on a monthly cycle and disbursed by the last working day of the month via direct bank transfer to the account registered with Finance. Payslips, YTD summaries, and attendance-linked pay computations (including LOP deductions where effective workdays fall short of days in the month) are available for download through the HR portal at all times.

12.3 Annual Compensation Review

Fixed pay is reviewed annually in April, informed by performance ratings, market benchmarking, and internal pay equity analysis. Off-cycle adjustments may be made for promotions, retention, or significant scope changes.

13. Benefits & Perks

13.1 Statutory & Health Benefits

- Provident Fund (PF) contribution as per statutory requirement.
- Group medical insurance covering the employee, spouse, and up to two dependent children.
- Group personal accident and term life insurance.
- Gratuity as per the Payment of Gratuity Act, on completion of 5 years of continuous service.
- Annual health check-up reimbursement up to ₹5,000.

13.2 Leave & Time-Off Perks

- Flexible festival holidays: employees may swap up to 2 declared holidays for alternate regionally relevant dates.
- Volunteering leave: 2 paid days per year for approved community service.

13.3 Learning & Growth

- Learning & development budget of ₹40,000 per year for courses, certifications, and conferences.
- Internal tech talks and a quarterly hack-day for exploratory engineering work.
- Conference sponsorship for accepted speakers/authors at recognised industry conferences.

13.4 Additional Perks

- One-time home-office setup allowance of ₹15,000 for remote/hybrid employees.
- Employee referral bonus for successful technical hires.
- Cab reimbursement for employees working past 9:00 PM or on approved weekend shifts.
- Parental transition support, including a phased return-to-work option following parental leave.

14. Travel & Expense Policy

14.1 Booking Travel

All business travel must be booked through the Company's approved travel desk or self-booked and claimed against the entitlement matrix below, with prior manager approval raised at least 3 working days before departure for domestic travel and 10 working days for international travel.

14.2 Entitlement Matrix

Grade	Domestic Air	Hotel (per night, cap)	Per Diem
Associate / Engineer	Economy	₹5,500	₹1,200
Senior Engineer / Lead	Economy (flex where >5 hrs)	₹7,500	₹1,500
Principal / Manager	Economy Plus	₹9,500	₹1,800
Director & above	Business (sectors >3 hrs)	₹12,000	₹2,200

14.3 Submitting Claims

Expense claims must be submitted through the Finance portal within 15 days of travel completion, with original invoices or digital receipts attached. Claims submitted after 45 days require Finance Head approval and may be declined thereafter.

14.4 Non-Reimbursable Items

- Alcoholic beverages, except at Company-approved client entertainment events with prior sign-off.
- Personal entertainment, mini-bar charges, and spa or wellness services.
- Traffic fines, lost-baggage fees, or penalties arising from personal negligence.

15. IT, Equipment & Asset Management

IT assets — laptops, monitors, access cards, mobile devices, and software licences — are issued against an Asset Allocation Form and remain Company property throughout the employment relationship.

15.1 Standard Issue

Engineering roles are issued a standard-configuration laptop appropriate to their function (for example, higher-memory configurations for ML engineers running local model experimentation), with upgrade requests routed through the IT portal and approved based on documented business need.

15.2 Software & Licensing

Only Company-procured or approved open-source software may be installed on Company devices. Requests for new tools, including third-party AI coding assistants or model APIs, must go through IT and Security review before use on any device holding Company or client data.

15.3 Loss, Damage & Return

Loss or damage must be reported to IT within 24 hours; repeated loss due to negligence may result in a partial cost recovery per the Asset Policy. All assets must be returned in working condition on the last working day as part of the exit clearance process.

16. Information Security & Data Protection Policy

Employees handling source code, model weights, training data, or customer data must follow the Company's Information Security Policy at all times. This policy is treated with particular seriousness given the nature of our work building AI systems on client and third-party data.

16.1 Data Classification

Classification	Examples	Handling Requirement
Public	Marketing material, published blog posts	No special handling
Internal	Internal wikis, non-sensitive process docs	Company accounts only
Confidential	Source code, financials, employee records	Access on need-to-know basis; encryption at rest
Restricted	Client PII, training datasets with personal data, model weights under NDA	Explicit approval, encryption, and audit logging required

16.2 Core Obligations

- Never commit credentials, API keys, or customer data to source control; use the approved secrets manager.
- Use only Company-approved cloud accounts and storage for any proprietary or customer data, including training or evaluation datasets used in ML pipelines.
- Enable multi-factor authentication (MFA) on all Company accounts.
- Encrypt Restricted-classification data at rest and in transit using Company-approved standards.
- Report suspected data incidents or security vulnerabilities to the Security team within 24 hours of discovery via the incident portal or security@ alias.

16.3 Use of Generative AI Tools

Personal or unapproved use of generative AI tools on confidential Company or customer data requires prior approval from the Security and Legal teams. Approved coding assistants must be configured per the IT-issued hardening guide, with data-sharing/training settings disabled where the tool would otherwise use Company code or data to improve third-party models.

16.4 Incident Response

Suspected breaches trigger the Incident Response Runbook: containment within 4 hours of confirmation, stakeholder notification per the severity matrix, and a blameless post-incident review within 5 working days. Employees are never penalised for promptly reporting a genuine mistake.

17. Responsible AI & Model Governance Policy

As a Company building applied machine learning systems, including retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) pipelines, we hold ourselves to a higher standard of care in how models are built, evaluated, and deployed. This section applies to all engineers, data scientists, and researchers building or operating models or model-backed features.

17.1 Model Review Board

Any model or pipeline intended for production use — including a new RAG retrieval component, ranking model, or fine-tuned generation model — must be reviewed by the Model Review Board prior to launch. Review covers intended use, evaluation methodology, known limitations, and a rollback plan.

17.2 Data Provenance & Consent

Training, fine-tuning, and retrieval-corpus data must have a documented, lawful provenance. Personal data used in any pipeline requires a documented lawful basis, and client data used to build or evaluate models may not be reused for another client's engagement without explicit contractual permission.

17.3 Evaluation & Bias Testing

Before production release, models must be evaluated against a documented test set covering accuracy/quality metrics relevant to the use case (for example, retrieval precision/recall and answer faithfulness for RAG systems) as well as basic checks for demographic or representational bias where the system affects decisions about people.

17.4 Human Oversight

Systems that materially affect a person's access to services, employment, credit, or similar high-stakes outcomes must include a meaningful human review step before an adverse decision is finalised, and must expose a clear mechanism for the affected person to contest the outcome.

17.5 Guarding Against Prompt Injection & Data Leakage

RAG and agentic systems that ingest external or user-supplied content must treat that content as untrusted input, apply the Company's approved input-sanitisation and prompt-injection mitigations, and must not allow retrieved documents to trigger unintended tool actions without explicit, logged authorisation.

17.6 Model & Prompt Change Management

Changes to production prompts, retrieval sources, or model versions are treated as code changes: they require peer review, a documented evaluation run against the regression test set, and a recorded rollback path before deployment.

18. Intellectual Property & Open Source Policy

18.1 Ownership of Work Product

All code, models, designs, documentation, and other work product created by an employee within the scope of their employment, using Company resources, or relating to the Company's actual or anticipated business, belongs exclusively to the Company, consistent with the IP assignment clause of the employment agreement.

18.2 Use of Open Source Software

Open-source components may be used in Company products only after licence review confirms compatibility with commercial distribution (permissive licences such as MIT, Apache-2.0, and BSD are generally pre-approved; copyleft licences such as AGPL require Legal sign-off before use).

18.3 Contributing to Open Source

Employees wishing to contribute to external open-source projects using any Company time, resources, or knowledge gained on the job must seek approval through the Open Source Contribution form to confirm no confidential information or client-derived logic is disclosed.

18.4 Publications & Patents

Employees wishing to publish research papers, blog posts, or file patents based on work performed at the Company must route the request through Legal and the relevant engineering director for review at least 15 working days before the intended submission or filing date.

19. Confidentiality & Client Data Handling

Employees routinely have access to confidential client information, including proprietary data used to train or evaluate models. This access is a privilege tied strictly to business need.

19.1 Non-Disclosure Obligations

Confidential information may not be disclosed to any third party, including friends, family, or other clients, during or after employment, except as required by law or with the prior written consent of the Company and the relevant client.

19.2 Client Data Segregation

Client data and derived artefacts (embeddings, fine-tuned model weights, evaluation sets) must be stored in the client-specific environment designated for that engagement and must never be copied to a personal device, personal cloud account, or another client's environment.

19.3 Data Retention & Deletion

On completion or termination of a client engagement, client data is retained only for the period specified in the contractual data retention schedule, after which it is securely deleted and deletion is logged and confirmed to the client where contractually required.

20. Non-Compete & Non-Solicitation

During employment, employees may not engage in any business activity that directly competes with the Company. Post-employment restrictions are limited to what is enforceable under applicable Indian law and are set out, where applicable, in the individual employment agreement.

20.1 Non-Solicitation of Employees

For 12 months following separation, former employees agree not to solicit current employees to leave the Company for another employer or venture, consistent with the terms of their employment agreement.

20.2 Non-Solicitation of Clients

For 12 months following separation, former employees who had direct client relationship responsibility agree not to solicit those specific clients for competing services, consistent with the terms of their employment agreement.

21. Social Media & Public Communications

Employees are encouraged to share their professional pride in the Company's work, subject to the guidelines below.

21.1 Personal Social Media Use

- Do not share confidential information, unreleased features, client names, or screenshots of internal systems.
- Make clear that personal views expressed are your own and not the Company's, particularly on divisive topics.
- Do not use Company branding, logos, or client logos in personal posts without approval from Marketing.

21.2 Speaking to Media or at Public Events

All media enquiries and requests to speak publicly on behalf of the Company must be routed to the Marketing/Communications team. Individual conference talks about general technical topics (not disclosing client or proprietary information) may proceed with manager awareness.

22. Grievance Redressal Procedure

Employees who experience a workplace concern not covered by the POSH Policy — for example, disputes with a manager, unfair treatment, or workload concerns — may raise it through the grievance process below.

22.1 Steps

14. Informal resolution: raise the concern directly with your manager or the other party where safe and appropriate to do so.
15. Formal submission: if unresolved within 10 working days, submit a written grievance to People & Culture via the HR portal.
16. Investigation: People & Culture investigates and responds with a proposed resolution within 15 working days.
17. Escalation: if dissatisfied, the employee may escalate to the Department Head or, for matters involving senior leadership, to the Ethics Committee referenced in Section 24.

22.2 Non-Retaliation

No employee will face adverse action for raising a grievance in good faith. Any perceived retaliation should be reported immediately to People & Culture.

23. Disciplinary Policy & Procedure

23.1 Categories of Misconduct

Category	Examples
Minor Misconduct	Repeated tardiness, missed deadlines without communication, minor policy lapses
Serious Misconduct	Breach of confidentiality, harassment, falsification of records, conflict of interest non-disclosure
Gross Misconduct	Theft, fraud, data exfiltration, violence, or serious safety violations

23.2 Progressive Discipline

18. Verbal counselling, documented in the HR system.
19. Written warning, with a defined improvement period.
20. Final written warning, often paired with a Performance Improvement Plan.
21. Termination of employment, for continued or gross misconduct.

The Company reserves the right to move directly to a later stage — including immediate termination — for gross misconduct, without progressing through earlier stages, subject to a fair investigation and the employee's right to respond.

23.3 Right to Be Heard

Before any disciplinary action beyond verbal counselling, the employee will be informed of the allegation in writing and given a reasonable opportunity to respond, either in writing or at a meeting with a colleague present if requested.

24. Whistleblower & Ethics Hotline Policy

The Company maintains a confidential Ethics Hotline for reporting suspected violations of law, financial irregularity, serious safety concerns, or serious breaches of this handbook, including concerns that are difficult to raise through the regular management chain.

24.1 How to Report

Reports may be submitted anonymously or with attribution through the Ethics Hotline portal or by email to ethics@clearquote.exampledomain, and are reviewed by the Ethics Committee, comprising representatives from Legal, People & Culture, and an independent board member.

24.2 Protection Against Retaliation

Employees who raise a concern in good faith, even if the concern is ultimately not substantiated, are protected from retaliation. Knowingly filing a false report, however, is itself treated as misconduct under Section 23.

25. Health, Safety & Wellbeing

The Company is committed to providing a safe working environment, whether in-office or remote.

25.1 Workplace Safety Committee

Each office location maintains a Safety Committee responsible for fire drills (conducted at least twice yearly), first-aid readiness, and maintaining an up-to-date emergency evacuation plan posted on each floor.

25.2 Ergonomics

Employees experiencing discomfort from their workstation setup, in-office or at home, may request an ergonomic assessment through Facilities, which may result in adjustable furniture or equipment recommendations.

25.3 Mental Health & Employee Assistance Programme

Confidential counselling support is available through the Employee Assistance Programme (EAP) at no cost, covering up to 6 sessions per year with a licensed counsellor, accessible directly without manager involvement.

25.4 Reporting Incidents

Any workplace hazard, harassment concern, or safety incident should be reported to your manager or People & Culture immediately, and serious incidents are logged in the Safety Register and reviewed by the Safety Committee within 5 working days.

26. Business Continuity & Emergency Response

The Company maintains a Business Continuity Plan (BCP) to minimise disruption from events such as natural disasters, extended power or connectivity outages, or public health emergencies.

26.1 Roles & Activation

The Business Continuity Lead, appointed by leadership, is authorised to activate the BCP, which may include temporary shift to full remote work, designation of a backup office location, or activation of the crisis communication tree.

26.2 Employee Responsibilities

Employees should keep emergency contact details current in the HR portal and follow instructions issued through official Company channels during an activated BCP event, prioritising personal safety above all else.

27. Environmental & Sustainability Policy

The Company is mindful of the environmental footprint of its operations, including the computational cost of training and running machine learning models.

27.1 Operational Practices

- Preference for energy-efficient cloud regions and right-sized compute for training and inference workloads where it does not compromise client commitments.
- Paperless-by-default office processes, with printing available but discouraged for routine documents.
- Responsible e-waste disposal for retired IT equipment through certified recyclers.

28. Employee Recognition & Rewards

28.1 Spot Recognition

Managers and peers may issue Spot Awards through the HR portal for notable contributions, accompanied by a small monetary reward and public recognition in the monthly all-hands.

28.2 Annual Recognition

Annual awards are presented for categories including Engineering Excellence, Client Impact, and Culture Champion, nominated by peers and reviewed by a cross-functional panel.

29. Retirement, Superannuation & Gratuity

The Company complies with all applicable statutory retirement benefit schemes.

29.1 Provident Fund

Both employer and employee contribute to the Employees' Provident Fund at the statutory rate, deducted automatically each pay cycle and reflected in the monthly payslip.

29.2 Gratuity

Employees who complete 5 or more years of continuous service are eligible for gratuity as per the Payment of Gratuity Act, 1972, payable on separation, retirement, or death.

30. Separation & Exit Policy

30.1 Notice Period

The standard notice period is 60 days for confirmed employees and 30 days during probation, unless otherwise stated in the employment contract. The Company may, at its discretion, provide pay in lieu of notice, or relieve an employee earlier than their notice period ends while continuing to pay out the balance.

30.2 Exit Process

22. Submit written resignation to your manager and People & Culture, and confirm the last working day.
23. Complete knowledge-transfer documentation and handover of ongoing projects to a nominated colleague.
24. Return all Company assets, including laptops, access cards, and any physical media, and revoke personal device access to Company systems where applicable (BYOD).
25. Attend an exit interview and complete full-and-final settlement, typically processed within 45 days of the last working day, including any gratuity, leave encashment, and reimbursements due.

30.3 Involuntary Separation

Where employment is terminated by the Company for reasons other than gross misconduct, severance (if any) is determined per the employment agreement and applicable law, and outplacement support may be offered at the Company's discretion.

30.4 Rehire Eligibility

Former employees who left in good standing are generally eligible for rehire and are encouraged to apply for future roles; eligibility is reviewed case by case by People & Culture.

31. Engineering Practices & Code Review Standards

Consistent engineering practices reduce production incidents and make it possible for any engineer to safely work in any part of the codebase. These standards apply to all production and client-facing repositories.

31.1 Code Review Requirements

- Every change to a production repository requires at least one approving review from someone other than the author.
- Changes touching model inference, retrieval logic, or prompts require review from a second engineer familiar with the Responsible AI & Model Governance Policy (Section 17).
- Reviewers are expected to respond to review requests within one business day; urgent hotfixes may be fast-tracked with post-hoc review, logged as such.

31.2 Testing Standards

New features require automated test coverage appropriate to risk: unit tests for core logic, integration tests for service boundaries, and — for ML components — evaluation-set regression tests that must pass before merge. Test coverage expectations are documented per-repository in each project's CONTRIBUTING guide.

31.3 Documentation Expectations

Every service and pipeline must maintain a README covering purpose, ownership, how to run locally, and how to interpret its key metrics or evaluation results. Architectural decisions with long-term consequences should be captured as lightweight Architecture Decision Records (ADRs) in the repository.

32. Data Science Experiment & Reproducibility Standards

Reproducibility is treated as a first-class engineering concern, not an afterthought, particularly for experiments that inform decisions later reviewed by the Model Review Board.

32.1 Experiment Tracking

All model training and evaluation runs intended to inform a production decision must be logged in the Company's experiment tracking system, capturing dataset version, hyperparameters, code commit hash, and evaluation metrics.

32.2 Dataset Versioning

Training, evaluation, and retrieval-corpus datasets must be versioned rather than mutated in place, so that any production model or RAG index can be traced back to the exact data snapshot used to build it.

32.3 Environment Reproducibility

Experiments should run from a pinned, version-controlled environment definition (for example, a lockfile or container image) so that results can be regenerated by another engineer without undocumented manual steps.

33. Vendor & Third-Party Risk Management

The Company engages third-party vendors for infrastructure, tooling, and, at times, model APIs. Each new vendor introduces potential data-handling and continuity risk that must be assessed before onboarding.

33.1 Vendor Onboarding

Any vendor that will process Company or client data — including third-party model or embedding API providers — must complete a security questionnaire and, where the vendor handles Restricted-classification data, a data processing agreement, before integration begins.

33.2 Ongoing Review

Critical vendors are reviewed annually for continued compliance, financial stability, and any reported security incidents. Procurement maintains the vendor register referenced during client security audits.

34. Client Engagement & Statement of Work Governance

Client commitments — including data usage rights, model ownership, and support SLAs — are governed by the signed Statement of Work (SOW) or Master Services Agreement, not by verbal or informal understandings reached during delivery.

34.1 Scope Changes

Any material change to project scope, data access, or deliverables must be documented as a change order and approved by both the client and the Company's engagement lead before implementation.

34.2 Sub-Processing & Data Flow Documentation

Where a client engagement involves any third-party sub-processor (for example, a hosted model API), the data flow must be documented and disclosed to the client per contractual obligations, consistent with the Vendor & Third-Party Risk Management Policy (Section 33).

35. Records Retention Policy

The Company retains business records for the periods required by law or sound business practice, and securely disposes of records once the retention period lapses, unless subject to a litigation hold.

Record Type	Retention Period	Owner
Payroll & statutory records	8 years	Finance
Employment contracts & personnel files	Duration of employment + 7 years	People & Culture
Client contracts & SOWs	Duration of contract + 7 years	Legal
Security incident records	5 years	Information Security
Model training/evaluation logs	Per client contract, default 3 years	Engineering

36. Workplace Violence Prevention & Substance Policy

36.1 Workplace Violence

The Company has zero tolerance for threats, intimidation, or acts of violence on Company premises or at Company-sponsored events. Any such incident should be reported immediately to Facilities Security and People & Culture, and, where there is imminent danger, to local law enforcement.

36.2 Alcohol & Substance Use

Employees may not report to work, or remain at work, under the influence of alcohol or non-prescribed controlled substances. Moderate alcohol consumption is permitted only at approved Company social events for employees of legal drinking age, consumed responsibly.

37. Immigration & International Assignment Support

Employees relocating internationally for a client engagement, or requiring work-authorisation support, should engage People & Culture at least 8 weeks before the anticipated travel or relocation date to allow time for visa or work-permit processing.

37.1 Company Support

Where the Company sponsors a work authorisation, associated statutory fees are borne by the Company; personal travel document fees (for example, passport renewal) remain the employee's responsibility unless otherwise agreed.

38. Internal Mobility Policy

Employees who have completed at least 12 months in their current role are encouraged to apply for internal openings in other teams, subject to current manager awareness before a formal offer is extended.

38.1 Process

26. Apply through the internal careers portal.
27. Inform your current manager once you reach the final interview stage, to allow for a constructive transition conversation.
28. Agree a handover timeline with both managers, typically not exceeding 4 weeks.

39. Technology Acceptable Use Policy

This policy sets expectations for everyday use of Company-provided technology, complementing the Information Security Policy (Section 16).

39.1 Email & Messaging

Company email and chat tools are the official channel for business communication and are subject to periodic administrative review for security and compliance purposes, consistent with applicable law and with reasonable expectations of privacy for personal correspondence.

39.2 Internet Use

Reasonable personal internet use during breaks is permitted. Access to categories such as gambling, adult content, or known malicious sites is blocked at the network level and any attempted access is logged.

39.3 Bring-Your-Own-Device (BYOD)

Personal devices used to access Company email or chat must have a passcode, device encryption enabled, and must accept the Mobile Device Management (MDM) profile issued by IT, which permits remote wipe of Company data only in the event of loss, theft, or offboarding.

Appendix F: Frequently Asked Questions

Q: I've exhausted my leave balance but need one more day off — what happens?

The day will be recorded as Loss of Pay (LOP) unless your manager approves an advance against next year's Earned Leave, subject to People & Culture sign-off, consistent with the attendance codes described in Section 7.1.

Q: Can I use a personal ChatGPT-style tool to help write code faster?

Only tools approved by IT and Security, with training/data-retention settings configured per the hardening guide, may be used — and never with Restricted-classification data. See Section 16.3.

Q: Who do I talk to if I disagree with my performance rating?

Start with your manager, then escalate to People & Culture if unresolved, following the Grievance Redressal Procedure in Section 22.

Q: Does the 60-day notice period apply during probation?

No — the notice period during probation is 30 days, per Section 3.1; the 60-day period applies after confirmation.

41. Acknowledgement

I confirm that I have read and understood the policies described in this Employee Handbook, and I agree to comply with them as a condition of my continued employment.

Employee Name: _____ Employee ID: _____

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Appendix A: Public Holiday Calendar (Illustrative)

Date	Occasion
26 Jan	Republic Day
Mar (variable)	Holi
Apr (variable)	Good Friday
15 Aug	Independence Day
Sep (variable)	Ganesh Chaturthi
02 Oct	Gandhi Jayanti
Oct/Nov (variable)	Diwali
25 Dec	Christmas

Exact dates are published annually by People & Culture in December for the following calendar year and account for regional/state variations across office locations.

Appendix B: Approval Authority Matrix (Illustrative)

Action	Approver
Leave up to 5 days	Reporting Manager
Leave beyond 5 consecutive days	Reporting Manager + Department Head
Domestic travel booking	Reporting Manager
International travel booking	Department Head + Finance
New vendor/tool onboarding (data access)	IT Security + Legal
Production model launch	Model Review Board
Expense claim above ₹25,000	Department Head + Finance

Appendix C: Glossary of Terms

Term	Definition
COF	Compensatory Off — a day off granted in lieu of work performed on a holiday or weekend
LOP	Loss of Pay — unpaid absence beyond available leave balance
OKR	Objectives and Key Results — the Company's quarterly goal-setting framework
PIP	Performance Improvement Plan
POSH	Prevention of Sexual Harassment (statutory framework and internal policy)
RAG	Retrieval-Augmented Generation — an AI architecture that grounds model outputs in retrieved documents
IC	Internal Committee constituted under the POSH Act
BCP	Business Continuity Plan
EAP	Employee Assistance Programme

Appendix D: Policy Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of Change
1.0	Jan 2023	Initial handbook release
2.0	Jan 2024	Added Remote & Hybrid Work Policy; revised leave entitlements
2.1	Jul 2024	Updated compensation structure and benefits
3.0	Jan 2025	Added Responsible AI & Model Governance Policy; expanded Information Security Policy
3.2	Jan 2026	Consolidated grievance, disciplinary, and whistleblower procedures; added appendices

Appendix E: Key Internal Contacts

Function	Contact
People & Culture	peopleandculture@ (HR portal ticketing preferred)
IT Helpdesk	ithelpdesk@ / in-app chat on the IT portal
Information Security	security@ / incident portal
Ethics Hotline	ethics@ / anonymous web form linked from the HR portal
Internal Committee (POSH)	Contact list published on HR portal, refreshed on membership change
Employee Assistance Programme	EAP provider details on HR portal — confidential, available 24/7

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